

User Document: Learning Aid or Visual Glossary

 tracigardner.github.io/TechComm/assignments/user-doc/user-doc-assignment-v2.html

September 1, 2026

User Document Learning Aid or Visual Glossary

Your Task

Worth 15% of your course grade

Prepare a **user-facing document** that provides a learning aid or visual glossary for the employees at your client's company to use as they work to improve communications with customers, colleagues, and the public.

You work as a Consultant at **Maroon + Orange Digital**, a company that helps their clients improve their communication with customers, colleagues, and the public. **See the [full scenario](#)** for all the details on the writing situation.

Review Markel & Selber Ch 20 for help as you work on this project. Check your work with the [User Document Self-Check](#) as you work.

Assignment Learning Objectives

▼ Hide the Learning Objectives

By completing this assignment, you will develop your ability to:

- Translate specialized or technical information into a clear, helpful document that supports real-world action or decision-making by a non-expert audience.
- Design a usable, accessible document that meets the needs of a specific audience by applying plain language principles, strong visual communication strategies, and effective document design (CRAP: contrast, repetition, alignment, proximity).
- Choose the most appropriate user-facing document structures based on your topic and the needs of your audience.
- Demonstrate audience awareness by tailoring your tone, structure, and content to support users in understanding, navigating, or acting on a complex subject with ease and confidence.

Your Audience

Write your project for **non-expert users**—specifically the employees at the client company. See the [full scenario](#) for more details.

These readers should be able to use the document to better understand the concepts you define and apply them to their own work.

Assignment Requirements

Basic Requirements

- **Length:** 1 page (front only).
- **Sources:** Cite borrowed definitions, information, procedures, and visuals using your field's documentation style.
- **Plain Language:** Use concise, concrete, reader-friendly language. Explain or avoid unfamiliar jargon.
- **Tone:** Be helpful, clear, and informative rather than academic or overly formal.
- **Design:** Use contrast, repetition, alignment, and proximity (CRAP) to organize information effectively.

Content & Usability

- Help readers **understand and apply** the concepts, not simply learn definitions.
- Organize the page with **headings, lists, white space, and other visual cues** so readers can find information quickly.
- Combine **visuals and explanatory text** to help readers understand the concepts.

Formatting Requirements

- **Page:** 8.5" × 11", portrait orientation.
- **Margins:** .25".
- **Spacing:** Single or 1.15 line spacing; skip a line between paragraphs.
- **Color:** Use a white or full-bleed background (background color covers the entire page, or, in other words, bleed off the page) and high-contrast colors.
- **Paragraphs:** Do not indent.
- **Font:** Use one font: Arial, Calibri, Verdana, Aptos, or Helvetica.
- **Headings:** Use a clear visual hierarchy; headings should be larger than the text below them.

TIP: The default heading sizes in Word and Google Docs follow this guideline automatically.

Example User Documents

- [5 Affordable Housing Policies](#)
- [Assisting Those in Distress](#)
- [Community Solar Panels: Benefits and How to Join](#) ([Transcript of the Image](#))
- [Credit Score Fairness](#)
- [Five Key Terms About Money Everyone Should Know](#)
- [Interpretive Pillars of Accessibility](#) ([Transcript of the Image](#))
- [Key Concepts in AI-Driven Assistive Robotics](#)
- [Using SMART Goals to Achieve Financial Freedom](#)

Success Tips

- Review the examples to see ways you can use document design to make your document easier to understand and use.
- Ask a friend to read your document. If they get confused, revise for clarity.
- Break your ideas into short, manageable segments (chunks) so readers never face a wall of text.
- Test your document with your word processor's accessibility review tools to ensure that it's design is easy for your audience to read. In Word, go to the *Review Ribbon*, and choose the *Check Accessibility* button.

Optional AI Feedback

You can submit a draft to your preferred generative-AI tool (e.g., Copilot, HokieAI, ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude) for feedback. If you do, follow these guidelines:

- **Keep** the original draft untouched.
- **Use** a prompt that asks AI to review your draft and provide suggestions for improvement only. (No direct revisions)
- **Save** the AI comments or revision advice. I may ask to see your AI feedback if I have a question.
- **Add a [submission comment](#)** that identifies which AI tool(s) you used and how you used the tools (in other words, what did you ask AI to do?).

Submission Details

- Save your assignment as a PDF to ensure that your document formatting shows properly in Canvas.
- Upload the final version of the assignment on this page.

Avoid these common errors

- Don't email your assignment. I grade all work in Canvas.
- Don't link to your assignment. You need to upload a PDF.

How You'll Be Graded

Check the rubric below for full assessment criteria.

Once I add feedback, you'll find comments in annotations on the document and in the rubric.
Allow a week for me to add feedback.